# ■ THE DAILY GOODS STORY SCOUT - Tuesday, September 29, 2026

## TODAY'S RUNDOWN SLOTS

## THE LIST (5 stories)

### ■■ *Chuck Grassley, oldest sitting US senator, laments dying in office under a Democratic governor*

***The Angle:*** *Chuck Grassley is the oldest sitting U.S. Senator, and he's now on record saying he'd rather not die in office if it means a Democratic governor gets to pick his replacement - a wild, out-loud admission of exactly how the political sausage gets made.*

- **Chuck Grassley** is currently the **oldest sitting U.S. Senator**
- He's reportedly said he'd prefer not to pass away in office **under a Democratic governor**
- The story landed on **r/nottheonion** - real news that reads like satire
- Reason it matters: in most states, **the governor appoints a Senate replacement** if a senator dies in office

**The Debate Starter**

- Should there be an age limit for serving in Congress - and does this comment prove why?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://abcnews.com/Politics/chuck-grassley-oldest-sitting-us-senator-laments-dying/story?id=136832758

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### ■ *Police investigate after toddler pulls out loaded gun at Michigan daycare*

***The Angle:*** *A daycare full of toddlers had a live, loaded gun in it — and the twist is the parent now in custody is a police officer, the person you'd expect to know better about gun storage. It's a gun-safety story with a built-in irony that'll get parents and gun owners both talking.*

- A toddler pulled out a **loaded pistol** at a daycare in **southeast Michigan** on **Monday**.
- One of the child's parents — a **police officer** — has been **taken into custody**.
- Officials say the **investigation is ongoing**, no further details released yet.

**The Gut-Check Question**

- If a cop's kid can bring a loaded gun to daycare, how confident are you your own gun storage is actually toddler-proof?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://abcnews.com/US/wireStory/police-investigate-after-toddler-pulls-loaded-gun-michigan-136843186

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### ■ *ShinyHunters hackers say they won't leak sensitive FBI data*

***The Angle:*** *A hacking crew just admitted to breaching the FBI itself and is now playing PR — promising not to publish the data while admitting they already handed some of it to reporters. It's a wild trust-us moment from a group that just proved you can't trust them.*

- The group behind the breach is called **ShinyHunters**
- They say they will **not publish** the FBI data they obtained
- They admit they **can't guarantee** what happens to data **already shared with journalists**
- The target of the breach was the **FBI** itself

**The Debate Starter**

- Do you believe a hacking group's promise not to leak stolen federal data, or is 'trust us' the least trustworthy sentence in tech?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/world/shinyhunters-say-they-wont-release-fbi-data-9.7361716?cmp=rss

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### ■ *Canada led a 2022 deal to protect the world's nature. Has there been progress since then?*

***The Angle:*** *Canada helped broker a major global pact back in 2022 to protect the planet's nature, and a fresh report card is now out checking whether countries actually kept their word — classic promises-vs-action fodder for a talk segment.*

- **Canada** helped lead a landmark **2022** global agreement aimed at protecting nature worldwide.
- A new assessment has just been released measuring how much real progress has been made since that deal was signed.

**The Report Card**

- Four years after the big promise — is the planet actually better off, or was it just a photo-op?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/science/canada-nature-protected-deal-progress-9.7358840?cmp=rss

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### ■ *'Backrooms,' 'The Shining' and Beyond: The Creepiest Liminal Spaces in Movies*

***The Angle:*** *The horror hit Backrooms turned an internet creepypasta into a box office smash, and it's reviving the whole 'liminal space' horror trope - those eerie, empty, fluorescent-lit places that feel wrong for no clear reason.*

- **Backrooms** started as an internet creepypasta before becoming a smash horror hit in theaters.
- The film has critics tracing a whole lineage of 'liminal space' horror, from empty office hallways to abandoned malls.
- **The Shining**'s Overlook Hotel gets cited as one of the genre's original creepy liminal spaces.

**The Debate Starter**

- What's the creepiest 'empty room' movie or real-life spot that's ever given you the chills?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://decider.com/2026/09/29/scary-movies-like-backrooms/

Backup options:

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### ■ *If You Use Money to Buy Things, You Should Read This Book*

***The Angle:*** *Surveillance pricing means companies can charge YOU a different price than the person next to you based on your data - and a new book says the popular theory that this actually helps poor shoppers is total nonsense.*

- **Lindsay Owens** just wrote a new book called **"Gouged"** breaking down how companies price-gouge using your own data
- She's debunking the **"Robin Hood theory"** - the idea that surveillance pricing takes from rich shoppers to give discounts to poor ones
- Her argument: that theory is a **myth** - it's not quietly helping anyone, it's just extracting more money

**The Debate Starter**

- Have you ever compared prices with a friend on the same app and found out you were charged more?

gizmodo.com (Tier 2) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 25 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://gizmodo.com/if-you-use-money-to-buy-things-you-should-read-this-book-2000816346

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## CANADIAN NEWS (3 stories)

### ■■ *U.S. Pressure Is Awakening an Energy Giant in Canada*

***The Angle:*** *Canada's energy sector has been sitting on the sidelines for years, but mounting U.S. pressure over trade and tariffs may be forcing a major player back into action - a story about how Washington keeps shaping decisions north of the border.*

**The Debate Starter**

- Should Canada be leaning harder into its own energy independence instead of reacting every time the U.S. applies pressure?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.wsj.com/business/energy-oil/u-s-pressure-is-awakening-an-energy-giant-in-canada-162bd958?st=5TxToM

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### ■ *Hamilton steel plant to lay off 500 workers as U.S. tariffs prompt 'survival' move*

***The Angle:*** *Half a thousand Hamilton families just got hit with layoff notices, and the company's blunt reason — U.S. tariffs — makes this a real gut-check on how trade fights south of the border are landing on Canadian paycheques.*

- A **Hamilton steel plant** is cutting **500 jobs**.
- The company is pointing straight at **U.S. tariffs** as the cause.
- Management is framing the move as a **'survival'** measure, not just a cost-cutting choice.

**The Debate Starter**

- 500 jobs gone in Hamilton over U.S. tariffs — is this the first real sign Canadian workers are paying the price for the trade war?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/hamilton/stelco-tariffs-trump-9.7361216

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### ■■ *Grave of boy who vanished at residential school found decades later, First Nation looks for others like him*

***The Angle:*** *This taps into one of the most painful, still-unresolved threads in Canadian history — a First Nation community finally locating the grave of a child who disappeared decades ago at a residential school, and now searching for others who met the same fate.*

- A **First Nation** community has located the **grave of a boy** who went missing at a **residential school decades ago**.
- The discovery is part of a broader search effort to identify **other children** who disappeared under similar circumstances.

**The Gravity Check**

- Stories like this are a reminder that the reckoning with Canada's residential school system is still actively unfolding, not history that's been closed.

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/indigenous/sturgeon-lake-cree-nation-residential-school-search-9.7359102?cmp=rss

Backup options:

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### ■■ *LNG Canada to move forward with Phase 2 expansion project in Kitimat, B.C.*

***The Angle:*** *LNG Canada is greenlighting Phase 2 of its massive Kitimat export terminal, basically doubling down on Canada's bet that liquefied natural gas is the next big energy export - huge for jobs and the economy out west, but it's also reigniting the climate-vs-economy fight.*

- **LNG Canada** is moving ahead with **Phase 2** of its export terminal in **Kitimat, B.C.**
- Phase 2 would roughly **double** the facility's existing export capacity
- The original project is one of the **largest private infrastructure investments** in Canadian history

**The Debate Starter**

- Big energy jobs for B.C. vs. Canada's climate goals - which one wins the argument for you?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/british-columbia/carney-lng-canada-announcement-9.7361817?cmp=rss

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### ■ *Stelco to lay off 350 steelworkers at Hamilton plant, union says*

***The Angle:*** *Hundreds of steelworker families in Hamilton are about to feel this - a major layoff at one of Canada's iconic industrial employers always ripples beyond just the plant floor.*

- **Stelco** is laying off **350 steelworkers** at its **Hamilton plant**
- News surfaced through the **union**, not a company announcement
- Hamilton has long been synonymous with Stelco and Canadian steel manufacturing

**The Watercooler Question**

- Anyone in our listening area got family or friends who work the line at Stelco - what are you hearing?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMiugFBVV95cUxNcUkzV3JqTXZmMGRtRGVRaW9qSnNrb3FRSlo5UWFwb3h0c3oyQW1VeXh3OU5IRnVxT1hhcWY4elROUy02cUttTEp5NnRsNzBZTHkyVEFaMEZHTGtscUFoOVNPTVRiaU1GYXBiMTFkYnBBRkY5d2hOOTZBX2I3UklHaWRTMjVXVHdIekhqXzl3dVBZVzVteTdYX2ZlZHVBTWpxbU1xWDN4VHc4aW1oY0lpZWRtaTVvT1FaMFE?oc=5

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### ■ *Two Starbucks locations in Ottawa closed as part of company restructuring*

***The Angle:*** *Starbucks trimming stores in the capital is a local gut-check on how the coffee giant's broader corporate shake-up is hitting Canadian streets - and a reminder for regulars to double check before their next drive-by order.*

**The Debate Starter**

- Which Ottawa Starbucks run did you just lose, and are you loyal to the brand or ready to jump ship to a local coffee spot?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMisgFBVV95cUxNT2F2YzFvc0RsbkdEZ2VjVWRHV3d1a1I1bW55YjJra2FnMGRwdnFxZUplWlhodFpMX1NpY3Z5VmQ1M2Zhamp3YlpDZEdwNjRVN1hIdFJFZ21rNjFkc3owYXdERjR6STBUbHZtWFhVOVVWbk1rZHhxei10RE1Tc2FLVmVveUwwNktBUjVDQVB0alJyQ1JrUmlaczVzWnpPWTNOY21fME9YUzk4UWZuVm5nSWZ3?oc=5

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## ENTERTAINMENT (4 stories)

### ■ *KATSEYE, Megan Thee Stallion, Tate McRae & Megan Moroney to Perform at 2026 Victoria’s Secret Fashion Show*

***The Angle:*** *The VS Fashion Show is back and swinging for every demo at once — pop, hip-hop, country, all on one runway. That genre mashup alone is worth a segment: who's actually watching for who?*

- **KATSEYE** is on the bill, riding their breakout year as a global pop girl group.
- **Megan Thee Stallion** joins the lineup, bringing hip-hop star power to the runway.
- **Tate McRae** adds pure pop-choreography energy to the show.
- **Megan Moroney** rounds it out, giving the lineup a country crossover moment.

**The Debate Starter**

- Out of KATSEYE, Megan Thee Stallion, Tate McRae, and Megan Moroney — who are you actually tuning in for?

X/Twitter @Billboard (Tier 1) | Score: 80/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 23 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/billboard/status/2104904262627033273

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### ■ *KATSEYE, Megan Thee Stallion, Tate McRae and Megan Moroney are all set to perform at the 2026 Victoria's Secret Fashion Show.*

***The Angle:*** *The Victoria's Secret Fashion Show is back as a pop-culture moment, and this lineup mixes a K-pop-adjacent girl group with a country crossover star and two of pop's biggest names right now — that's a real genre clash worth unpacking.*

- **KATSEYE** is confirmed to perform at the **2026 Victoria's Secret Fashion Show**
- **Megan Thee Stallion** joins the performer lineup
- **Tate McRae** is set to hit the runway stage as a performer
- **Megan Moroney** rounds out the lineup, bringing a country presence to the show

**The Debate Starter**

- Out of KATSEYE, Megan Thee Stallion, Tate McRae and Megan Moroney — who's the one you're actually tuning in to see?

X/Twitter @Billboard (Tier 1) | Score: 80/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 23 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/billboard/status/2104904056732795068

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### ■ *The college dean scene in Promising Young Woman (2020): "We get accusations like that all the time, one or two a week... What would you have me do? Ruin a young man's life every time we get an accusation like this? I have to give them the benefit of the doubt."*

***The Angle:*** *This five-year-old moment from the Oscar-winning film is making the rounds again on Reddit because the dean's excuse-making still sounds ripped from real headlines - it's a quick, quotable way to get into how institutions handle accusations.*

- The scene: a college dean brushing off assault accusations, saying **'we get accusations like that all the time, one or two a week.'**
- His justification: **'What would you have me do? Ruin a young man's life every time we get an accusation like this?'**
- It's resurfacing on **r/fauxmoi** as one of *Promising Young Woman's* most-quoted, most uncomfortable moments.

**The Debate Starter**

- Ask listeners: does this scene hit harder now than when the movie came out in 2020?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://v.redd.it/kbit1ml1dcsh1

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### ■ *'Coyote vs. Acme' comes to streaming — Where to watch the new movie at home*

***The Angle:*** *This is the Looney Tunes movie that famously got shelved and nearly buried entirely — now it's finally landing on-demand, which is exactly the kind of underdog Hollywood story that gets people curious to watch just to see what almost never happened.*

- **Coyote vs. Acme** is now available to watch at home on-demand.
- The film had a long, bumpy road to release before finally getting here.

**The Watercooler Check**

- Are you actually renting this one, or just relieved it exists at all?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/29/entertainment/coyote-vs-acme-is-now-streaming-where-to-watch-at-home/

Backup options:

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### ■ *Yankees-Red Sox Preview + David Stearns Press Conference Takeaways | The Show Ep. 220*

***The Angle:*** *It's Yankees-Red Sox in the postseason, the rivalry that never needs an excuse to matter, and it's paired with the Mets' offseason mystery kicking off after Stearns' year-end presser.*

- **Joel Sherman** and **Jon Heyman** break down the **Yankees-Red Sox Wild Card Series** matchup
- The duo digs into what challenges the **Red Sox** pose for the **Yankees**, and where the **Yankees'** biggest advantages lie
- They also react to **David Stearns'** end-of-season press conference
- Discussion turns to what the **Mets** need heading into the offseason

**The Debate Starter**

- Yankees or Red Sox — who's walking out of this Wild Card series, and why?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/video/yankees-red-sox-preview-david-stearns-press-conference-takeaways-the-show-ep-220/

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### ■ *'SNL U.K.' Sets Cynthia Erivo, Danny Dyer and James Norton as Next Hosts*

***The Angle:*** *SNL U.K. just locked in its Season 2 host lineup, and it's stacked — Cynthia Erivo, fresh off her Wicked run, headlines alongside Rivals' Danny Dyer and House of the Dragon's James Norton. It's a fun "who ya got" moment for anyone who's watched the flagship U.S. version try out different hosts for years.*

- **Danny Dyer** ('Rivals') kicks things off **Oct. 10** with musical guest **Sasha Keable**
- **James Norton** ('House of the Dragon') hosts **Oct. 17**, with **the Streets** performing
- **Cynthia Erivo** closes out the run on **Oct. 24** alongside musical guest **Blossoms**
- This marks **Season 2** of the U.K. spinoff of the iconic sketch show

**The Debate Starter**

- Out of the three, who do you think nails the hosting gig — Erivo, Dyer, or Norton?

variety.com (Tier 2) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 25 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/tv/global/snl-uk-cynthia-erivo-danny-dyer-james-norton-host-1236870930/

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### ■ *Surprise Adam Lambert Performance Caps Hit-Filled George Michael Tribute at 2026 VMAs - The Hollywood Reporter*

***The Angle:*** *The VMAs went all-in on nostalgia, stacking a George Michael tribute with three buzzy young voices and then dropping in a surprise Adam Lambert cameo — perfect fodder for who-nailed-it-best chatter.*

- **Raye**, **Sombr** and **Teddy Swims** each covered George Michael classics during the set
- The tribute was timed to nearly **40 years** since the release of his **Faith** album
- **Adam Lambert** popped up for a surprise performance to close out the segment
- It comes ahead of a live **Faith** tour album and a feature-length project tied to the late singer, who died in **2016**

**The Nostalgia Hook**

- Ask listeners: which cover stole the night, and who do you trust with a George Michael song?

Hollywood Reporter (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: http://www.hollywoodreporter.com/music/music-news/adam-lambert-george-michael-tribute-2026-mtv-vmas-1236713332/

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### ■ *Taylor Swift Premieres Star-Filled 'Patient Zero' Music Video at VMAs - Variety*

***The Angle:*** *Taylor Swift used the VMAs stage for the world premiere of her "Patient Zero" video, and she didn't just bring a music video — she brought Colin Farrell and Dakota Johnson along for what she's calling a ghost story, not a love story.*

- **Taylor Swift** gave "**Patient Zero**" its official world premiere at the **MTV VMAs** Sunday night.
- The video costars **Colin Farrell** and **Dakota Johnson**.
- Swift herself is pitching it as a twist: "It's a love story? Hardly — it's a **ghost story**."

**The Debate Starter**

- Colin Farrell AND Dakota Johnson in one Taylor video — who do you think steals the scene?

Variety (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/music/news/taylor-swift-vmas-patient-zero-music-video-premiere-1236876944/

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## TRENDING TODAY

### ■ *The new research found that using social media, especially within 30 minutes of waking, was associated with more than twice the odds of depression among U.S. adults.*

***The Angle:*** *Almost everyone reaches for their phone first thing in the morning — this is basically a universal habit, and new research links that exact 30-minute window to more than double the odds of depression, which makes it a story every listener can immediately measure themselves against.*

- Study found scrolling social media within **30 minutes of waking** was linked to **more than double the odds of depression** among U.S. adults.
- The research zeroes in on timing, not just total usage — it's specifically about that first half hour of the day.

**The Self-Check Moment**

- Be honest — is your phone the first thing you touch when you wake up, and does this number make you want to change that?

**ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN**

- **Step 1: The Morning Confession** - 60 seconds, kick off the segment -> Both hosts admit on air exactly how many minutes after waking they check their phone — no rounding down.
- **Step 2: Phone Lines Open** - Live caller bit -> Ask listeners to call in and share their real 'first phone touch' time, then react live to how close it is to that 30-minute danger zone.

Reddit r/futurology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.oregonstate.edu/news/social-media-offers-little-substitute-real-life-emotional-support-research-suggests

Backup options:

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### ■ *The Apple Next Vision Pro Is Reportedly on 'Life Support' - Gizmodo*

***The Angle:*** *Apple's $3,500 VR headset never took off, and now Bloomberg's Mark Gurman says the sequel is quietly getting starved of resources inside the company - a real signal Apple may be admitting the whole bulky-headset bet was wrong.*

- Bloomberg's **Mark Gurman** reports the next-generation **Vision Pro** is on **'life support'** internally at Apple
- Apple could technically still ship another headset down the road, but it's reportedly not a priority right now
- Word is Apple is instead leaning into a **'much less awkward'** alternative - widely read as a hint toward smart glasses over another bulky headset

**The Debate Starter**

- Did Vision Pro fail because it was ahead of its time, or because nobody actually wants to wear a $3,500 ski mask?

Gizmodo.com (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://gizmodo.com/the-apple-next-vision-pro-is-reportedly-on-life-support-2000817916

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### ■ *Tom Brady Gave Ex Gisele Bündchen a 'Middle Finger' Through Social Media After Divorce, New Book Says - People.com*

***The Angle:*** *Brady and Bündchen's split has been tabloid gold for years, and a new book claiming he threw social-media shade at her post-divorce is exactly the kind of petty-celebrity-drama tea that gets everyone talking.*

- A new book claims **Tom Brady** gave ex-wife **Gisele Bündchen** a symbolic **"middle finger"** via social media after their divorce.
- The claim comes from a new book about the former couple, according to **People**.

**The Relatable Bit**

- Be honest - who here has fired off a petty post-breakup social media move of their own?

**ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN**

- **Step 1: Confess Your Pettiest Post-Breakup Move** - Quick phone-in or social callout -> Ask listeners to text or call in with the pettiest thing they've done on social media after a breakup - hosts share their own first to break the ice.
- **Step 2: Rank the Petty Scale** - 30-second host banter -> Hosts debate where Brady's alleged move ranks compared to classic breakup petty moves (posting with someone new, cryptic captions, unfollowing) - build a quick 'petty scale' from 1-10.

People (via Google News) (Tier 2) | Score: 74/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMixgFBVV95cUxOelZ5NXJUTktsQUdaX0tFMDRXS2lXeWNGckZuNS1sWFlTWGlzdjNTeHRBZnVLRWw2djI0RGl0NTlHNXdNNl9xY1lqQlB0M0RFYlBWS0xuRzZIRTEtT2l3TEVkeTdBM3V5T1oxaXE5Zm1VUlltVl90SHFYb1lYU0drTGtzNVA3a3p0WUdwV3M1Yjg4b3pKb183RkdxSVRtaXpBQXEtMllkVXNkVmw3S3k3dTJCOXBvbFBCSVRnNHRjSkhBZ2w3RVE?oc=5

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## LIFESTYLE CHAT

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### ■ *1 in 8 cancer cases worldwide are caused by infections, study finds*

***The Angle:*** *This flips the usual cancer conversation from lifestyle and genetics to something a lot more preventable — infections — which means vaccines and screenings could be bigger cancer-fighting tools than people realize.*

- New global study finds **1 in 8 cancer cases worldwide** are linked to infections, not lifestyle or genetics.
- Puts the spotlight on preventable culprits — the kind of thing a vaccine or early screening could catch.
- Reframes cancer prevention as partly an infection-control issue, not just diet and habits.

**The Debate Starter**

- Does knowing an infection could cause cancer make you more likely to get screened or vaccinated?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/health/cancer-infections-9.7361622?cmp=rss

Backup options:

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### ■ *Tylenol during pregnancy not linked to autism, ADHD, major review finds*

***The Angle:*** *This directly answers a fear that's been swirling around expecting parents for a while now, especially with all the political noise linking Tylenol to autism — a big review just says that link isn't there, which is huge relief-slash-conversation fuel for anyone who's ever popped a Tylenol while pregnant.*

- A **major review** of the research found **no link** between taking **Tylenol (acetaminophen) during pregnancy** and kids later being diagnosed with **autism or ADHD**.
- The findings directly push back on a scare that's had plenty of expecting parents second-guessing every headache pill.

**The Phone-In Trigger**

- Did you take Tylenol while pregnant and spiral a little when the autism headlines hit — does this review actually put your mind at ease?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cidrap.umn.edu/anti-science/tylenol-during-pregnancy-not-linked-autism-adhd-major-review-finds

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### ✍■ *Taylor Swift fans lower climate concerns to justify her carbon footprint. When confronted with news about the excessive pollution generated by her private jet, highly identified fans tend to rationalize the behavior, with a decrease in their personal intentions to engage in climate-friendly actions.*

***The Angle:*** *New research suggests the more diehard a Taylor Swift fan you are, the more likely you are to shrug off her private jet pollution - and even care less about your own climate footprint afterward. It's a fun mirror for how far any of us bend our values to protect a fave.*

- New study finds hardcore **Taylor Swift** fans downplay climate concerns when confronted with her **private jet** pollution.
- Researchers say "highly identified" fans rationalize the behavior instead of criticizing it.
- Those same fans reported *lower* personal intent to take climate-friendly action afterward.
- Findings surfaced via **r/science**, reigniting the celebrity-carbon-footprint debate.

**The Debate Starter**

- Would you make excuses for your favorite star's carbon footprint - or hold them accountable?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.psypost.org/taylor-swift-fans-lower-climate-concerns-to-justify-star-s-carbon-footprint/

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## CLOSER: THE KICKER/GOODBYES

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### ■■ *UK: councils to be given powers to take control of empty homes after six months*

***The Angle:*** *Three hundred thousand empty homes sitting in England while people can't find a place to live — this is the kind of "finally, someone did something" story that gets people fired up on both sides.*

- **Housing Secretary Angela Rayner** unveiled the plan on day one of Labour's party conference in **Liverpool**
- An estimated **300,000 homes** across England currently sit empty
- Local councils would get expanded power to seize derelict/empty homes and put them back into use
- Reform targets the existing **Empty Dwelling Management** rules

**The Debate Starter**

- Smart fix for a housing crisis, or government overreach on private property — where do you land?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.lbc.co.uk/article/councils-to-get-new-powers-to-bring-empty-homes-back-into-use-5Hjdj7p_2/

Backup options:

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### ■ *Driver accused of driving SUV into a Kroger because he needed to use the bathroom*

***The Angle:*** *It's a classic 'not the onion' gut-punch — a property-damage crime story so absurd it basically writes its own punchline, perfect for a quick laugh before the goodbye.*

- **A driver** allegedly plowed an **SUV** straight into a **Kroger** grocery store
- His stated reason: he **needed to use the bathroom**
- No further details on the SUV, the store location, or the damage were included in the source

**The Excuse-O-Meter**

- What's the worst excuse you've ever heard for property damage — rate this one out of 10.

**ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN**

- **Step 1: Set the scene** - 10 seconds -> Host reads the headline dead serious, then pauses for the reaction beat.
- **Step 2: Rate the excuse** - 30 seconds -> Hosts each give the 'gotta pee' excuse a score out of 10 for believability.
- **Step 3: Phone-in / text-in** - Open lines -> Ask listeners to text in their own worst 'I panicked and did something dumb' excuse.
- **Step 4: Read a few live** - 1-2 minutes -> Hosts pick 2-3 funniest listener excuses to read before tossing to goodbyes.

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.click2houston.com/news/local/2026/09/28/driver-accused-of-ramming-through-rosenberg-grocery-store-upset-because-he-needed-to-use-the-bathroom/

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## FLEX (cap check: THE GREAT DEBATE 2/5 this month; TECH TALK 3/3 this month; Advice/Relationship Cluster 4/3 this month)

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### ■ *Where to Watch ‘The Swan: Behind the Mirror,’ New Doc Detailing TV’s Most Controversial Reality Show in History*

***The Angle:*** *A new documentary is dragging one of reality TV's most jaw-dropping relics back into the light - a show that put women through three months of cosmetic surgery and called them 'ugly ducklings.' It's a perfect gut-check on how far we've come (or haven't) with beauty standards on TV.*

- The original **'The Swan'** aired in **2004**, taking self-described **'ugly ducklings'** through months of extreme cosmetic surgery makeovers.
- The new documentary, **'The Swan: Behind the Mirror,'** is directed by **Erin Lee Carr**.
- It's revisiting the show **22 years later**, reexamining just how extreme early-2000s reality TV really got.

**The Debate Starter**

- Was 'The Swan' just extreme even for its time, or could a show like this actually get made today?

www.hollywoodreporter.com (Tier 3) | Score: 37/90 (12 fit + 4 source + 21 quality) -> BACKUP

URL: https://www.hollywoodreporter.com/tv/tv-news/watch-the-swan-behind-the-mirror-2026-documentary-streaming-1236713425/

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## ADDITIONAL CANDIDATES (no specific segment match, but scored well on source/quality - producer's call on where these fit)

### ■ *Flock Safety CEO's Home Marked 'Public Toilet' After It Was Blurred on Street View*

***The Angle:*** *The guy running a company that watches everyone else's license plates blurred out his own home on Street View — so the internet's revenge was tagging it a public restroom. It's the internet's favorite genre: petty, poetic justice.*

- The CEO of **Flock Safety**, a company known for license-plate surveillance cameras, had his own home blurred out on **Google Street View**.
- In response, internet users reportedly got the address relabeled online as a **"Public Toilet."**
- The story is making rounds on **r/nottheonion** for the sheer irony of a surveillance exec dodging the same visibility his company profits from.

**The Irony Meter**

- A guy who built a business watching your car wants privacy for his own front door — fair trade, or comedy gold?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.techtimes.co.uk/flock-safety-ceo-google-maps-backlash-surveillance-scrutiny-1808813

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## BREAKOUT WATCH (below the show's usual engagement bar - included on editorial judgment, not metrics; producer's call)

### ■ *An 11-year-old from Harrow has become the youngest woman grandmaster in chess history*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): An 11-year-old becoming the youngest woman grandmaster ever is a clean, verifiable record-breaking human-interest story with instant emotional pull and no controversy to slow sharing.
***The Angle:*** *An 11-year-old from Harrow has become the youngest woman grandmaster in chess history*

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://sheets.works/story/keep-making-history?r=stories

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### ■■■ *Crows are being given naloxone after suspected drug overdoses in Prince George*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Crows getting naloxone for opioid overdoses is a genuinely bizarre, never-seen-before angle on the opioid crisis that hits the 'wait, what?'

shareability sweet spot — and it's already independently posted twice, a sign of organic momentum.
***The Angle:*** *A wildly bizarre headline that fuses the real opioid crisis with straight-up absurdist local news - the kind of 'wait, what?' story that's tailor-made for the goodbye segment.*

- Story out of **Prince George, British Columbia** - crows reportedly showing signs of suspected drug overdoses.
- Wildlife responders have been giving the birds **naloxone**, the same overdose-reversal drug (Narcan) used on humans.

**The Jaw-Drop Moment**

- Nature's weirdest sign of the opioid crisis yet, or the most 'only in 2026' headline you'll read all week?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/british-columbia/crows-overdose-prince-george-naloxone-9.7358727

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## ■ *A TV journalist is set to be crowned as king of a traditional monarchy in Uganda*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A TV journalist becoming an actual king is a startlingly novel real-life narrative arc that reads like fiction, the kind of premise people share just to prove it's real.
***The Angle:*** *A working TV journalist is about to trade the anchor desk for an actual throne in a traditional Ugandan kingdom — it's the kind of real-life plot twist that sounds made up but isn't, and it's tailor-made for a quick "wait, what?" moment on air.*

**The Reality Check**

- If you found out your co-anchor was secretly royalty, would you still let them get you coffee?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://apnews.com/article/uganda-tooro-kingdom-journalist-coronation-d0e9d2c065641a876c27faf7df2a2425

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## ■ *Book Award Winner Complains About White Paint Because of Its “Purity” and “Cleanliness”*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A prestigious award winner objecting to white paint over its 'purity' framing is tailor-made outrage/mockery bait for r/nottheonion's core audience and could easily snowball once screenshotted onto other platforms.
***The Angle:*** *A celebrated author is calling out a paint brand for marketing white as "pure" and "clean" — a classic case of someone finding hidden meaning in the most boring color on the shelf, and it's tailor-up for a quick did-they-have-a-point debate.*

- A **book award winner** is publicly objecting to a **white paint** product
- The complaint centers on the paint being marketed with words like **"purity"** and **"cleanliness"**
- Story's blowing up on **r/nottheonion** for how out-there it sounds at first glance

**The Debate Starter**

- Genuine critique of loaded language, or reaching way too hard over a paint can?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://thenewamerican.com/us/culture/book-award-winner-complains-about-white-paint-because-of-its-purity-and-cleanliness/

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## ■ *NYC man killed in freak accident after backpack got caught in subway doors https://t.co/uJeTRvOIXu https://t.co/wTUsKgRJCt*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A freak fatal accident involving a backpack and subway doors is a uniquely visceral, almost-unbelievable death that tends to spike shares purely on shock value.
***The Angle:*** *A bizarre, almost unbelievable freak accident in the NYC subway that instantly becomes a nightmare-scenario story every straphanger can picture themselves in.*

- A man in **New York City** was killed after his **backpack got caught in subway doors**, according to the **New York Post**.
- Officials are calling it a **freak accident** — details on exactly how it unfolded are still limited.

**The Nightmare Scenario**

- Be honest — how many of you have had a bag or coat sleeve catch in closing subway or train doors and had that split-second panic?

X/Twitter @NYPost (Tier 1) | Score: 52/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 5 quality - 10 penalty (Depressing/negative tone)) -> STRONG

URL: https://x.com/nypost/status/2104915909827494360

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### ■ *'Betrayed' Prince William tangled in another royal feud after family member opens up 'traumatic' chapter https://t.co/KXbVRdiu15 https://t.c*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Royal feud stories carry built-in global name recognition (Prince William) and 'traumatic' family drama is exactly the kind of tabloid hook that reliably outperforms its initial engagement.
***The Angle:*** *Another royal family member is going public with a 'traumatic' chapter and calling out Prince William directly — royal drama is always a ratings magnet, and 'betrayed' is a strong word for a royal to use on the record.*

- A royal **family member** is opening up about a chapter they call **'traumatic'**
- **Prince William** is described as feeling **'betrayed'** by the fallout
- Marks the latest in an ongoing string of **royal family feuds**

**The Debate Starter**

- Is the royal family ever going to catch a break, or is the drama just part of the brand at this point?

X/Twitter @NYPost (Tier 1) | Score: 72/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 15 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/nypost/status/2104891093556867489

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## FRANCHISE BANK

WHAT THE FRIDAY: 5 banked (+15 each when found)
- "Dramatic video shows naked man being pulled from East River by NYC cops" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-09)
- "Lady wtf, your kid is right there!" (X/Twitter @WomenBeingAwful, banked 2026-09-16)
- "Channing Tatum addresses claims he trolled ex Zoë Kravitz online using burner account: 'Wtf come on'" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-09-22)
- "VMAs 2026 best and worst moments: Dolly Parton tributes, Madonna's bizarre speeches" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-27)
- "Hundreds of lefties link arms for bizarre 'hands across the sand' protest against California oil drilling" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-28)

THROWBACK THURSDAY: 19 banked (+15 each when found)
- "John Oliver to Host Comic Relief Live's 40th Anniversary Show" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-09-09)
- "Where I was on 9/11: 4 people in N.L. share their stories of stepping up to help" (www.cbc.ca, banked 2026-09-11)
- "Gander mayor reflects on 25th anniversary of 9/11" (CTV News (via Google News), banked 2026-09-11)
- "Globe editorial: Nostalgia is no strategy for U.S. relations" (The Globe and Mail (via Google News), banked 2026-09-11)
- "Universal Studios Japan Celebrates Halloween With First R-Rated Attraction" (gizmodo.com, banked 2026-09-13)
- "'Practical Magic 2' Dazzles Up a Bit Of an Audience" (gizmodo.com, banked 2026-09-14)
- "The London revival of "Sunday in the Park With George" has been canceled following the exits of stars Ariana Grande and Jonathan Bailey." (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-14)
- "'Sunday in the Park With George' London Revival Canceled After Ariana Grande, Jonathan Bailey Exits https://t.co/cPQ2IIvYql" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-14)
- "'Sunday in the Park With George' revival scrapped after Ariana Grande, Jonathan Bailey exits" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-09-14)
- "Margot Robbie stuns in a retro bikini as she joins shirtless Bradley Cooper to shoot the Ocean's Eleven 1960s prequel on the French Riviera" (www.dailymail.co.uk, banked 2026-09-16)
- "Here's Why Fifth Harmony Fans Think the Girl Group Is Making a Comeback Ahead of Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-20)
- "NCT 127 Open 10th-Anniversary 'Neo City: The Redline' Tour With Sold-Out Seoul Run" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-22)

- "1Retro adds cloud saves to RetroArch, OpenEmu, and other gaming platforms" (www.techspot.com, banked 2026-09-22)
- "NCT 127 Open 10th-Anniversary ‘Neo City: The Redline’ Tour With Sold-Out Seoul Run" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-23)
- "‘The Visit’ at Pasadena Playhouse Review: The ’50s Absurdist Comedy Is Too Smug in Its Peak-Bleak View of Venal Humanity, but Jefferson Mays and Melinda Page Hamilton Are Worth the Visit" (variety.com, banked 2026-09-23)
- "Neil Patrick Harris to Star in ‘Damn Yankees’ Broadway Revival" (variety.com, banked 2026-09-27)
- "Neil Patrick Harris and Julianne Hough to Lead First Broadway Revival of Damn Yankees in Over 30 Years - People.com" (People (via Google News), banked 2026-09-27)
- "Neil Patrick Harris Will Lead Damn Yankees Broadway Revival Spring 2027 - Playbill" (Playbill.com (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-09-28)
- "Kawhi Leonard has fun with Ka’Wine & Dine revival at Raptors media day: ‘I can’t eat as much’" (Toronto Star (via Google News), banked 2026-09-29)

Newly banked this run:

- THROWBACK THURSDAY: "Kawhi Leonard has fun with Ka’Wine & Dine revival at Raptors media day: ‘I can’t eat as much’"

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## SOURCES SKIPPED THIS RUN:

- @CBCNews (fetch failed)
- @globalnews (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 1 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- @Gizmodo (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- Morning Brew (OpenCLI browser-scrape returned nothing - check Chrome/bridge)
- 2 story(ies) removed after slotting (content-safety and/or not-significant-enough for THE LIST/TRENDING TODAY; automatically backfilled where possible; see run log)

Scout Report Generated: 2026-09-29 09:40 AM